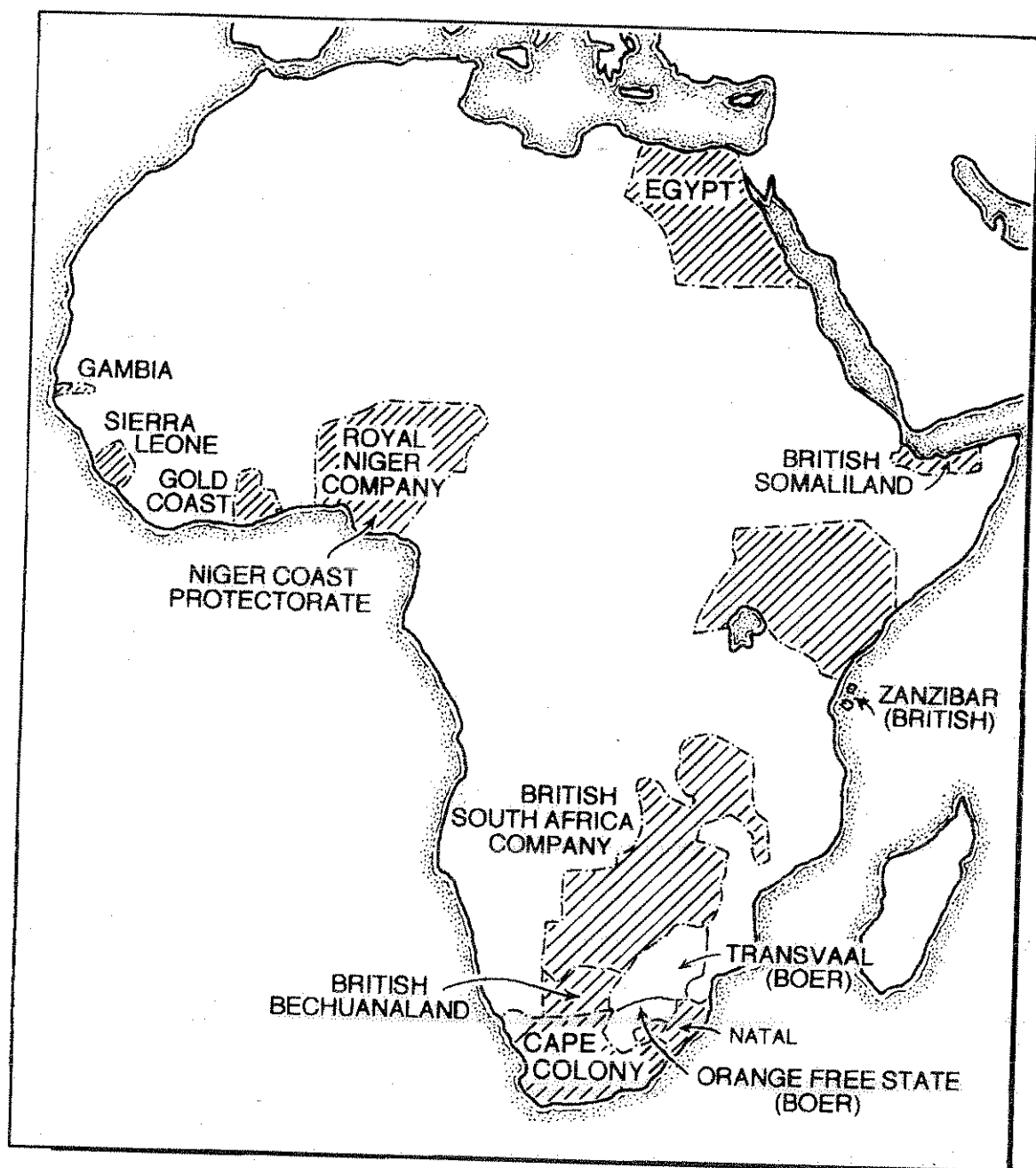




Map 2 British Possessions in Africa, 1895

A 'NEW IMPERIALISM'?

British overseas expansion in the late nineteenth century

BACKGROUND NARRATIVE

In the last two decades of the nineteenth century the major European powers engaged in a competition for territory in several parts of the underdeveloped world. More than one contemporary used the phrase a 'partition of the world' to describe this phenomenon, which affected the Pacific, the Far East and Africa. Of the powers 'scrambling' for empire, Britain emerged with the most substantial gains. It has been calculated that, between 1874 and 1902, Britain acquired an additional 4,750,000 square miles of territory, together with authority over almost 90 million people.¹ Her gains included the annexation of numerous South Pacific islands, the imposition of British authorities upon several Malay states and the conquest of Upper Burma.

It was in Africa, however, that the most striking advances were made. At the start of our period Britain's possessions in the 'Dark Continent' were relatively few and, where possible, she preferred informal influence to the political and financial burdens of direct control. In South Africa Britain had taken the Cape of Good Hope as a prize of the Napoleonic Wars. Natal, on the Cape's north-eastern border, had been acquired in 1843 with a view to strengthening Britain's presence on the shores of the Indian Ocean. In East Africa

British influence rested upon a commercial treaty with the Sultan of Zanzibar, an Arab potentate whose coastal domains occupied an important position on the trade route to India. Before the 1880s British involvement in the interior was minimal. Business interests had penetrated more extensively in West Africa. Here Britain possessed a handful of commercial territories between Gambia and the delta of the River Niger. Britain relied for the most part upon a network of relationships with local chieftains; outright annexations, such as that of Lagos in 1861, were exceptional. In common with most European powers, Britain was content to maintain an 'open door' for trade through collaboration with local leaders, supported by the threat of 'gunboat diplomacy' in the background. This was empire on the cheap, and by and large it was effective in securing regional influence for the imperial power.

After about 1880 the 'imperialism of free trade', as Jack Gallagher and Ronald Robinson termed it,² gave way to more formal control in many areas of the African continent. The occupation of Egypt in 1882 was at first presented as a limited intervention to restore good order and financial probity to a bankrupt province of the Ottoman Empire, but it steadily took on the character of a permanent occupation. In 1884–5 came the declaration of protectorates over the Somaliland in East Africa, and over Bechuanaland in the south. The granting of a royal charter to Sir George Goldie's Niger Company in 1886 was a preliminary to the establishment of two Nigerian protectorates thirteen years later. In 1889 Cecil Rhodes' British South Africa Company was chartered to extend British power northwards from Bechuanaland, into what would become Northern and Southern Rhodesia. In 1894–5 Uganda became a British possession and direct responsibility for Kenya was taken over from the Imperial British East Africa Company. The Sudan was conquered in 1898, enabling Britain to assume predominance in the whole of the Upper Nile region. It is not surprising that the search for explanations of these events should have generated a lively historiographical debate.

ANALYSIS: WHY DID BRITAIN PARTICIPATE IN THE 'SCRAMBLE FOR AFRICA' IN THE LAST TWO DECADES OF THE NINETEENTH CENTURY?

Lord Salisbury, who led Britain during the greater part of the 'scramble for Africa', remarked in 1891: 'I do not exactly know the cause of this sudden revolution. But there it is.'³ He was not the only person to find it hard to explain the process whereby, in less than two decades, Britain became overlord of one-third of the African continent. The earliest and frequently the most politically committed writers tended to focus on the economic arguments for expansion. Others have interpreted the scramble as an extension overseas of European great power rivalries in the wake of German unification in 1870. A still more influential explanation stresses the importance of British strategic interests in Northern and Southern Africa. A further fault line divides commentators who emphasise the primacy of decisions taken at the centre – the so-called 'metropolitan' approach – from those who seek explanations on the periphery of empire among the administrators, the commercial and missionary pressure groups and African tribes and cultures.

The economic argument for African expansion was popularised in the early years of the twentieth century by the radical writer J.A. Hobson, author of *Imperialism: A Study* (1902). Hobson's theory derived from his belief that the domestic market in Britain had contracted as a result of the unequal distribution of industrial profits. Financiers therefore chose to invest their surplus capital abroad, where both the returns and the risks were greater. Imperial expansion arose when these financial interests induced the government to intervene abroad in order to protect their investments. Thus, in Hobson's words, 'finance is . . . the governor of the imperial engine, directing the energy and determining the work'.⁴ The theory of 'under-consumption' has some validity for Southern Africa, where government involvement was certainly heightened following the discovery of diamonds close to Cape Colony in 1869. However, it seems to have limited application to other areas of Africa. The principal areas for British investment were the United States, Canada and Latin America. It has been estimated that seven-tenths of the total capital sent overseas between 1880 and 1914 was lent to Europeans transplanted abroad. Hobson's work was influenced strongly by his radical domestic agenda. One of the purposes of his critique of empire was to draw attention to the problem of low wages which, he argued, diminished the field for investment within the United Kingdom by restricting working-class purchasing power.

If the greater part of Africa was not, then, a lucrative zone for investment, it was certainly important as a source of raw materials for British industry. It is possible to explain British involvement in West Africa, for example, in these terms. The Niger region was an important source of palm oil, used in the soap, industrial lubrication and tinsplate industries. Until the intensive exploitation of Malaya in the early twentieth century, it was also a leading supplier of rubber for tyres and electrical insulation. The great chocolate manufacturers, Rowntree of York and Cadbury of Birmingham, fuelled demand for Nigerian cocoa. From the early 1880s the growing interest of French and German trading rivals in West Africa led British merchants to demand government intervention. The establishment of the Oil Rivers protectorate in 1884 and the chartering of the Royal Niger Company two years later were responses to intense economic conflicts.

Nonetheless, as Ronald Hyam points out, one should be careful not to portray the British government as the passive tool of trading interests. Governments made their own assessments of the national needs of British commerce and were selective about the assumption of expensive formal commitments. The head of the African Department of the Foreign Office, Percy Anderson, underlined the pragmatism of British policy in discussing French penetration of the western coast in 1883: 'Protectorates are unwelcome burdens,' he wrote, 'but in this case, it is . . . a question between British protectorates, which would be unwelcome, and French protectorates, which would be fatal.'⁵

The relationship between government and chartered company was essentially a contractual one, in which the former sought to minimise its responsibility for administration. Thus the Royal Niger Company agreed 'to undertake all internal native wars and maintain order without charge on the Imperial Treasury while the Imperial Government contracts to defend the Chartered Company against the aggression of foreign powers'.⁶ Technological development, especially in the fields of transport and weaponry, gave the companies a decisive edge over the capabilities of the native African tribes and reinforced a latent sense of Western racial superiority. Cecil Rhodes' buoyant claim that 'we are the first race in the world, and that the more of the world we inhabit the better it is for the human race'⁷ strikes a modern reader as incredibly arrogant. The sentiment was underpinned by the knowledge that possession of the rapid-firing Maxim gun placed entire tribes at the mercy of relatively small numbers of European adventurers.

As this was empire on the cheap, it was also highly favoured by the home government. Only with the arrival of Joseph Chamberlain at the Colonial Office in 1895 did a senior British political figure think

seriously of administering or developing tropical Africa at public expense. With his business background, Chamberlain viewed the Niger and Gold Coast hinterland as 'undeveloped estates', which a progressive imperial government should seek to exploit and improve. Yet even he was to meet resistance from a parsimonious Treasury when he sought to raise loans for colonial development. In any case, Chamberlain's activities do not help to explain Britain's initial involvement in tropical Africa.

An alternative interpretation, propounded by D.K. Fieldhouse and others in the 1950s and 1960s, views expansion in Africa as the projection of European rivalries into a new context. Supporters of this approach draw attention to the fact that the 'scramble' took place in the wake of important changes in the European balance of power following the Franco-Prussian War. In Fieldhouse's words, 'imperialism may best be seen as the extension into the periphery of the political struggle in Europe. At the centre the balance was so nicely adjusted that . . . no major change in the status or territory of either side was possible. Colonies thus became a means out of the impasse.'⁸

A variant on this theme was proposed by A.J.P. Taylor, who saw Bismarck as the key player in a strategy designed to prevent a Franco-British combination against Germany. Bismarck's statement that 'my map of Africa lies in Europe'⁹ reveals his true priorities. Far from desiring colonies for their own sake, Bismarck entered the imperial game in order to draw closer to France. The means by which this was to be achieved was a quarrel with Britain over African territory in which Germany had hitherto shown little interest. By laying claim to imperial power status, Germany provoked Britain to expand in Africa.

It does seem that concern over German ambitions in Africa played some part in the calculations of British policy makers. Britain's annexation of Bechuanaland, for example, followed Germany's establishment of a protectorate over Angra Pequena, on the coast of South-west Africa, in 1884. Fear that Germany intended to link up with the Boer Transvaal republic, thus threatening the security of Cape Colony and Natal, prompted a British occupation of the unclaimed coastal territory between the two. As the Colonial Secretary, Lord Derby, wrote to a colleague: 'there is a difference between wanting new acquisitions and keeping what we have: both Natal and the Cape Colony would be endangered . . . if any foreign Power chose to claim possession of the coast lying between the two.'¹⁰ A similar concern with German penetration of the Sultan of Zanzibar's dominions may explain the granting of a charter to the Imperial British East Africa Company in 1888, permitting it to administer and develop what would later become

Uganda and Kenya. Until then Sir William Mackinnon, who had founded the company as the East African Association, had striven in vain to attract government patronage.

It is noteworthy that, for all the intensity of their rivalry, the European powers usually contrived to settle their colonial disputes peacefully. The most ambitious example of this was the Berlin Conference of December 1884 on West Africa, at which ground rules for the partition of territory were worked out. The powers were required to prove 'effective occupation' and to inform their rivals before proceeding to annexation. According to Sir Edward Malet, who represented Britain at the talks, the aim was to help prevent 'the anarchy and lawlessness which must have resulted from the influx of traders of all nations into countries under no recognised form of government'. As Ronald Hyam argues, at the back of politicians' minds was the fear that by staking out increasingly confused rival claims, European powers might risk an outbreak of war among themselves. Native African rulers, for whom tribal conflicts were a fact of life, might support one European sphere of influence against another, thus dragging the imperial powers into mutual hostilities.¹¹

This discussion of great power calculations leads naturally to consideration of the influential 'strategic argument' originally advanced by Ronald Robinson and Jack Gallagher. *Africa and the Victorians*, published in 1961, broke new ground by drawing attention to the way in which crises on the periphery of empire could help to shape the reactions of the 'official mind' at the centre. The book's starting point was the importance for Britain of the maritime routes to India and the East. According to Robinson and Gallagher, it was instability at the southern and northern tips of Africa that drew Britain into actions designed to secure the Suez Canal and the Cape route respectively. The decision to occupy Egypt in 1882 was taken by a British government that had come to view Colonel Arabi's nationalist revolt as a threat to the security of the canal. From this action, it is argued, flowed the other events of the 'scramble'. France responded to the British presence in Egypt by seeking compensation in West Africa. Germany extracted concessions elsewhere, exploiting Britain's dependence upon the consent of an international commission for its management of Egyptian finances. In the 1890s Britain's need to strengthen its hold upon Egypt drew it further up the Nile, involving it in the annexation of Uganda and the military conquest of the Sudan. Britain's security requirements thus provided the driving force behind expansion. 'From start to finish the partition of tropical Africa was driven by the persistent crisis in Egypt. When the British entered Cairo on their own, the

Scramble began; and as long as they stayed in Cairo, it continued until there was no more of Africa left to divide.¹²

Robinson and Gallagher's thesis remains the most powerful challenge to the older economic interpretations of the scramble. It offers a plausible explanation of the British government's readiness in the late 1880s to interest itself in the commercially unpromising regions of East Africa. According to Robinson and Gallagher, economic development was 'more a consequence than a motive of the "Scramble"'. As an explanation of European rule in tropical Africa the theory of economic imperialism puts the trade before the flag, the capital before the conquest, the cart before the horse.¹³ Their emphasis on India's centrality to the thinking of British policy makers is well founded. By the 1880s India accounted for almost one-fifth of Britain's total overseas investment. It was the lynchpin of Britain's trade with Asia, a vital generator of revenue and a vast reservoir of military strength; in the words of Lord Salisbury, 'an English barracks in the Oriental seas'.¹⁴ Communications with India constituted 'the spine of prosperity and security' for the empire,¹⁵ and it is understandable that Britain should have gone to great lengths to protect them.

Yet another valuable insight of Robinson and Gallagher is their successful demonstration of the limited role played by popular pressure within Britain. Certain moments of high imperial drama, such as the death of General Gordon at Khartoum in 1885, could engage the passions of public opinion. A plethora of religious societies called stridently for government intervention to uphold the civilising mission of Western missionaries. Yet the evidence suggests that they had little practical influence on policy making. The shocking martyrdom of Bishop Hannington of East Africa in 1886 failed to change the Salisbury government's attitude to the region.

The annexation of Uganda had to await the arrival of a new government and a Foreign Secretary, Lord Rosebery, who was determined to override his colleagues' anti-interventionist prejudices. In order to make the case for annexation, he doctored a civil servant's memorandum on the subject and threatened resignation in order to secure a subsidy, necessary to delay the withdrawal of the ailing Imperial British East Africa Company. Finally, he 'improved' a report by Sir Gerald Portal, the commissioner responsible for investigating the situation. The eventual annexation was a tribute to Rosebery's persistence and was certainly not a foregone conclusion.

Nevertheless, the ideas of Robinson and Gallagher have not been received uncritically. It has been pointed out that the earliest stages of the scramble pre-dated the occupation of Egypt. France had initiated

forward moves in Senegal in 1879 and Tunisia had been claimed in 1881. King Leopold II of Belgium had begun penetration of the Congo region in the early 1880s, independently of British action elsewhere in the continent. The 'Egyptocentric' argument of *Africa and the Victorians* has been criticised for attempting to make one factor bear too heavy a burden of explanation. More recent studies of the period have moved away from the emphasis of Robinson and Gallagher upon the cool calculations of the 'official mind' in London. J.M. MacKenzie, for example, characterises the scramble as 'a combination of exaggerated hope and over-heated anxiety'.¹⁶ He explains it in terms of the conversion of a powerful and interlinked elite, composed of commercial, intellectual and official elements, to the dominant idea of imperialism. A variety of interests came to view the presumed opportunities offered by Africa as a solution to the economic pressures of the late nineteenth century. The lines between the business world and Whitehall became increasingly blurred as ties of social and family connection knitted together the disparate strands of the 'establishment'. Lord Aberdare, for example, who became chairman of the Royal Niger Company, was a former Home Secretary with considerable influence in the corridors of power.

In recent years an important variation on this theme has been offered in the work of P.J. Cain and A.G. Hopkins. Their interpretation is built around the concept of 'gentlemanly capitalism'. Cain and Hopkins are critical of older economic interpretations, which stress the importance of manufacturing interests in overseas expansion. Instead they emphasise the political influence of an elite based in the City of London and south-eastern England, deriving its wealth from the financial sector and closely linked to the landed interest. Whereas manufacturing entered a period of relative decline in the last quarter of the nineteenth century, finance and services continued to expand. They took advantage, moreover, of connections with the political elite which industrial interests had never enjoyed. Most historians have seen late Victorian Britain as a defensive power, conducting a rearguard action in the face of growing foreign competition. By contrast, Cain and Hopkins' perspective leads them to emphasise the continuing vitality of a state at the centre of the international financial system.

On this reading of events, the key element in the scramble for Africa was the growing interest of 'gentlemanly capitalism' in the continent. This was encouraged by the growth of regular steamship services after 1850 and the rise of large firms in the transactions sector, capable of running ships, financing large mining operations and advancing credit to local traders and producers. Cain and Hopkins argue that the

intervention in Egypt was precipitated by the nationalist movement's attempt to gain control of the country's budget. The Suez Canal was not at first in danger and, in any case, the Admiralty gave priority to the Cape route until the 1890s. Britain was drawn into North Africa not by strategic considerations but by pressure to ensure that Egyptian debts were serviced.¹⁷

Not all historians accept these claims for the centrality of the City to imperial policy making. Cain and Hopkins' portrait of Britain as a still dynamic imperial power on the eve of the Great War remains controversial. The publication in 1998 of a substantial review volume, *Gentlemanly Capitalism and British Imperialism: The New Debate on Empire*, indicated that the subject was far from closed.¹⁸ It is likely that the mechanics of the scramble for Africa will continue to arouse scholarly interest for some time to come.

Questions

1. Were strategic considerations more important than economic factors in promoting the scramble for Africa?
2. Did Robinson and Gallagher exaggerate the importance of Egypt in the scramble for Africa?

SOURCES

1. IMPERIAL POLICY IN EAST AFRICA

Source A: a memorandum by Clement Hill, a Foreign Office official, 20 October 1884.

The geographical position of the East Coast lays it more within the general area of our foreign policy than that of the West Coast. Our alternative route by the Cape to India may at any time make it important that we should have possession of, or at least free access to, good harbours: the importance is not less since the French movement in Madagascar. The Mahommedan element on the East Coast and the large Indian trade which is there carried on, with its connection, which if not close is none the less real, with all that concerns the Mahommedan world in the Soudan ... make it essential that we should secure a preponderating influence over its political future.

Commercially it has made great strides in the 10 years which have elapsed since the Slave export was checked and an impulse given to legitimate trade. Apart from the mineral wealth which is believed to exist between the coast and the great lakes, there is an unlimited capacity for the production of cattle, cereals, and all the usual articles of tropical trade.

Source B: Sir William Harcourt, Chancellor of the Exchequer in the fourth Gladstone government, argues against British involvement in Uganda, 20 September 1892.

I am very much exercised in my mind at the news from East Africa and Mombasa. As you will have observed the East African Company have 'thrown up the sponge' (being as I imagine insolvent), and a determined effort is being made to force the British government to take to the *damnosa haereditas* [cursed inheritance]. Rosebery has circulated a Memo. (for our consideration but not expressing his own sentiments), by Sir P. Anderson (of the F.O.), in the highest jingo tune advocating the annexation of the whole country up to the Albert Lakes with a view to the 'reconquest' of the Sudan via the Upper Nile . . . If we embark on this desperate business we shall have no end of trouble with the French and Germans, as indeed we already have . . . I see nothing but endless expense, trouble and disaster in prospect if we allow ourselves to *drift* into any sort of responsibility for this business, and devoutly hope we shall have nothing to do with it.

Source C: Sir Gerald Portal reports on East Africa for the Foreign Secretary, Lord Rosebery, August 1893.

Any other European power would be justified in taking the British place in Uganda if there is an evacuation, because of the Arab aspect of the problem . . . It is hardly possible that Uganda, the natural key to the Nile Valley . . . should be left unprotected and unnoticed by other Powers because an English Company has been unable to hold it and because Her Majesty's Government has been unwilling to interfere . . . All question of a complete evacuation of Uganda should be set aside.

Questions

1. Using Source A and your own knowledge, explain the importance attached by its author to 'Our alternative route by the Cape to India'. [4]
2. Explain the references to 'the highest jingo tune' (Source B) and 'an English Company' (Source C). [4]
3. What do the language and tone of Sources B and C reveal about the outlook of their respective authors? [6]
4. How reliable is Source B as evidence of British government attitudes towards imperial expansion in Africa in the 1890s? [4]
5. How complete a picture do these sources give of the factors influencing British policy in East Africa in the late nineteenth century? [7]

SOURCES

2. DIFFERING INTERPRETATIONS OF BRITISH INVOLVEMENT IN THE SCRAMBLE FOR AFRICA.

Source D: *The Economist* on the economic potential of Africa, 30 August 1890.

The trade of South Africa is in our hands and is considerable. The trade of the Lower Niger is also in our hands. But, apart from these, Algeria, Tunis and Egypt, are alone the countries of which the trade and finance are not really infinitesimal. There may be mining surprises in store. But the lands of tropical Africa are not usually suitable for a European population, and the present inhabitants are races which it must take a far longer time to civilise than those who look for immediate big results appear to think of. We do not, apart from surprises, look for any rapid development of either trade or financial success from these territories.

Source E: from a satirical poem by Hilaire Belloc, 'The Modern Traveller', published in 1898.

[The fictional character, William Blood, is the leader of an expedition against an African tribe.]

I never shall forget the way
That Blood upon this awful day
Preserved us all from death.
He stood upon a little mound,
Cast his lethargic eyes around,
And said beneath his breath:
'Whatever happens we have got
The Maxim gun, and they have not.'

Source F: J.A. Hobson on the role of investment in overseas expansion, 1902.

It is not too much to say that the modern foreign policy of Great Britain has been primarily a struggle for profitable markets of investment. To a larger extent every year Great Britain has become a nation living upon tribute from abroad, and the classes who enjoy this tribute have had an ever-increasing incentive to employ the public policy, the public purse, and the public force to extend the field of their private investment, and to safeguard and improve their existing investments... It is this economic condition of affairs that forms the taproot of

Imperialism. If the consuming public in this country raised its standard of consumption to keep pace with every rise of productive powers, there could be no excess of goods or capital clamorous to use Imperialism in order to find markets.

Source G: Ronald Robinson and Jack Gallagher on the causes of the partition of Africa, 1961.

By altering the European balance, the occupation of Egypt inflated the importance of trivial disputes in tropical Africa and set off a scramble. Quickened by the hope of prising the British out of Cairo, the French drove deep into west Africa, while the Germans took their opportunity to irrupt into east and west Africa, in an attempt to extort British support in Europe . . . Once the French and German governments for diplomatic purposes began to back their own traders against British firms, trade turned into a business of territorial claims. As long as the British remained trapped in Cairo, France and Germany had the opportunity and the incentive to challenge Britain in Africa.

In this roundabout way, the occupation of Egypt triggered off at last a secondary rivalry for possession of tropical Africa; and despite its small intrinsic value, began its partition among the Powers at the Berlin Conference of 1884-5.

Questions

1. Explain the references in Source G to 'the occupation of Egypt' and 'the Berlin Conference of 1884-5'. [4]
2. How would you explain the differing views of British overseas expansion given by Sources D and F? [5]
3. Which is more useful for an enquiry into the reasons for British overseas expansion in the late nineteenth century, Source D or Source F? [4]
- *4. How reliable as an historical source is a literary work such as the narrative poem from which Source E is taken? [5]
5. How full a picture do these sources give of the reasons for Britain's involvement in the scramble for Africa? [7]

Worked answer

*4. [This question requires an appreciation of the particular extract and an awareness of the strengths and weaknesses of literary works as historical evidence.]

The last two lines of the extract neatly encapsulate one of the reasons for the success of British imperial initiatives in Africa. The reference to

the rapid-firing Maxim gun stands for the technical and military advantages of European settlers over indigenous tribes. This example demonstrates the capacity of the literary form to present a topical issue in a memorable way. However, it is important to be aware of the bias of the author, who may not necessarily represent wider opinion. Moreover, the need to produce the work for sale to a mass market may involve some distortion of the truth. A poet (or novelist) is likely to place the entertainment value of the work above a responsibility for factual accuracy. In this particular case, the satirical intention of the author needs to be taken into account. The author has simplified a complex real-life situation for humorous effect. As numerous examples testify, from the Zulu War of 1879 to the South African conflict of 1899–1902, possession of superior fire-power did not always guarantee a rapid victory. Naturally, sober reflections of this kind cannot be allowed to intrude into a comic work.